future zeal by letting the convert himself arrive at the conviction that he was now truly set on the path to nirvana.

Instrumental in making Ashoka a zealous Buddhist, he revealed, was his association with the Sangha, the Buddhist mendicant order, a year and a half after he became a lay follower.[23] Such congregations of monks and nuns were by the third century BC known to exist in many parts of India. Precisely which branch of the Sangha enchanted him is not known, but Mahabodhi is a definite possibility since we learn from a later Ashokan epigraph that the emperor visited it in the tenth year of his consecration, a year which can be inferred to coincide with the time when he became fervent. The other possibility is that his constant interaction with monasteries in and around Pataliputra caused him to feel more deeply about his new religion. There is no way for us to know anything on this matter with certainty, nor what exactly transpired between Ashoka and the Sangha. That he became closely associated with it is all that he tells us, and this simply underlines that he was now seriously imbibing the teachings of the Buddha. What he learnt of the doctrines is likely to have been what had by then been established for the instruction of laypeople and fresh converts. The instructions included discourses of all kinds, especially those concerned with ‘giving, morality and heaven: the first emphasized the advantages of renunciation, the second revealed the harm, vanity and defilement of desires; the third mellowed, liberated, exalted and appeased the mind of the listener.’[24] Various texts that contained the teachings and discourses of the Buddha will also have been inhaled and digested, since some years later the emperor confidently offered advice to the Buddhist Sangha as well as to the laity on the texts that they should listen to and reflect upon.

For the Sangha, the conversion of the region’s most powerful man to a religion which the state had hitherto largely regarded as a philosophy of dissent against the Brahmanical faith was a coup of unimaginable